

Rajasthan Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) President C.P. Joshi is a busy man these days. But his residence bears no signs of the hustle-bustle that goes with an election run-up. The plain speaking professor prefers meeting ticket-seekers at his office to the embarrassment of some and the admiration of others. In sharp contrast is Ashok Gehlot, the former chief minister of Rajasthan, who has been travelling extensively to talk to people across the state, but not without inviting criticism within the party, this time from the high command.

The marked difference in the strategies of Joshi and Gehlot is perhaps one indication of just how disparate the Congress machinery in Rajasthan is today. Even after five years of being in the Opposition, the party remains directionless and has been unable to ride the proverbial anti-incumbency wave. As things stand, it appears that the Joshi-Gehlot combination will be the undeclared face of the Congress campaign in Rajasthan, during the November-end elections, with most other leaders confining themselves to their own little burrows and heir apparent Rahul Gandhi, focusing on countering Chief Minister



STATE OF DISARRAY

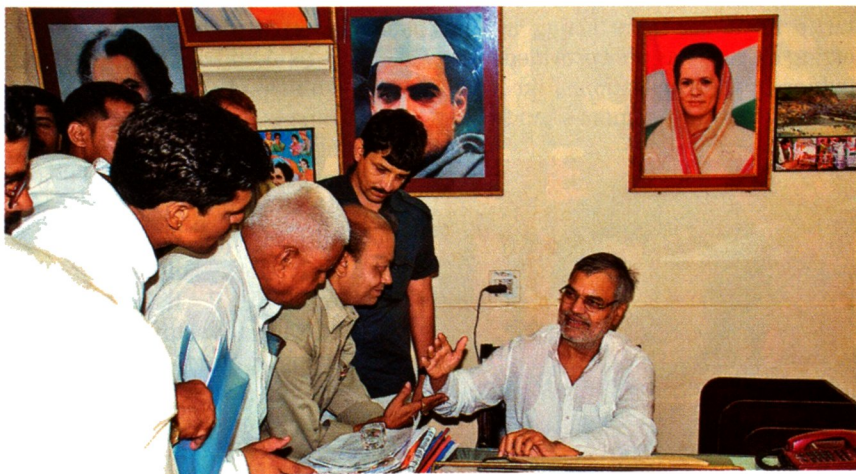
Instead of riding on the anti-incumbency factor, the Congress is clueless about its strategies as polls approach

though the campaign had been led by Jat veteran Paras Ram Maderna. To make matters worse, Gehlot refused to give Jats, who comprise 12 per cent of the state's population, the OBC status, thereby alienating them from the Congress and leading to the party's defeat in the 2003 elections. Since then, Congress President Sonia Gandhi has been wary of giving him a prominent role in the state.

Apart from this, the party high command is keen on infusing fresh blood by denying tickets to people above 70 years of age, those who have lost Assembly polls by more than 15,000 votes or two successive elections, and also to those who have contested Lok Sabha elections but lost in the Assembly segment. Although Joshi believes the Congress has a strong base at the district-level, the party is of the view that many district leaders have grown too old. They have been asked to participate actively in the campaigns but leave the candidature to younger leaders. This may result in quite a few veteran MLAs doing what Banwari Lal Sharma from Dholpur intends to do. Having won from his constituency five times, he may now opt out in favour of his son Ashok Sharma.

The stringent screening has left the Congress with little choice but to go with the Joshi-Gehlot combo for a state-wide role, while others will play a part in their own constituencies. What the sum total of such an equation will yield is something still being worked on. The answer, clearly, is elusive.

by Rohit Parihar



Vasundhara Raje.

Joshi, who is not very well-known outside the state, assumed office exactly a year ago. To his credit, he has succeeded in winning over a good majority of party workers with his straightforward talk. "My job is to develop the party's logistic support and create a cadre," says Joshi, indicating that he has more at stake in bringing the Congress closer to victory than har-

DARK HORSES: The party is not projecting either Gehlot (top) or Joshi

bouring hopes of the top job.

Traditionally, Rajasthan has seen the chief ministerial candidate lead the campaign when it has been in power, while it has been the PCC chief or the CLP leader at the helm if it has been in the Opposition. In 1998, Gehlot was appointed the chief minister even